

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4**PART A Group Interaction**

This article recently appeared on a news website:

Music groups no longer dominate the pop charts

When the British rock group The Beatles first visited America in 1964, it set off a musical explosion. Not only did this group become hugely popular around the world, but young people everywhere also started buying musical instruments and forming pop and rock groups of their own.

For the rest of the 20th century, music groups dominated the pop charts. In the year 2000, for instance, over 80% of the songs listed in the 'Hot 100' biggest musical acts compiled by Billboard magazine were by pop, rock or hip-hop groups.

How times have changed. According to recent data, very few of the hottest songs from the year 2024 were from music groups. In August 2024, only one group, Imagine Dragons, had a hit in the Global Top 50. Individual performers like Ariana Grande, Taylor Swift, Eminem and Dua Lipa now dominate the charts.

While there are many reasons for this trend, experts say that the biggest factor has been the rise of social media. As music executive Chris Price notes, social media "is mainly a solo activity. It's easier as an individual singer to express what kind of artist you are on YouTube or Instagram than for four people to do the same thing."

Another factor is the improved technology for recording music alone, as software like Ableton Live allows people to make high-quality music at home. "In the past, if you wanted to make music for people to dance to, you needed a band," says Price. "Now you just need a laptop."

Your group is discussing changes in pop music trends in recent years. You may want to talk about:

- whether music groups are popular in Hong Kong
- whether it is better to watch a performance by a music group or an individual performer
- how social media has affected pop music trends
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you like listening to music?
2. Would you like to be part of a music group?
3. Do boys and girls usually like the same kinds of music?
4. Should all children learn to play a musical instrument?
5. Do teens usually prefer music from Hong Kong or music from other places?
6. Do older and younger people in Hong Kong like the same kinds of music?
7. Is music important to young people these days?
8. Do you think music groups will completely disappear in the future?